▶ UTTARAKHAND

A MURDER CASE REBORN AS POLITICAL SPECTRE

The Ankita Bhandari case had never really gone away. Its unsolved 'VIP angle' now returns to haunt the BJP as pre-poll politics exhumes the trail

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

THE DEMAND FOR JUSTICE FOR ANKITA Bhandari has travelled a long way from the streets of Uttarakhand. In October, it reached India Gate in New Delhi, where Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi joined the 19-year-old's parents in a dramatic flash protest. In one evening, as TV cameras zoomed in on Ankita's weeping mother, one alleged aspect of the crime probe previously consigned to whispers and inferences suddenly became very public. Ankita's parents wanted the Centre to put on hold the appointment of Dushyant Kumar Gautam as Sikkim governor until the CBI completes its inquiry into the alleged "VIP" angle in the murder.

Five days later, Gautam took oath as governor at Lok Bhavan in Gangtok. The ceremony went ahead despite the family's appeal and a letter from Rahul to President Droupadi Murmu asking for a last-minute rethink. For the Congress, the sequence offered a fresh line of attack against the BJP. For Ankita's parents, it was another reminder that their central question has remained unanswered. Who was the VIP allegedly involved in the events that led to their daughter's death?

AN ANGLE GONE ABEGGING

Ankita, a receptionist at Vanantara resort near Rishikesh, went missing in September 2022. Her body was recovered from the nearby Chilla canal days later. Investigators said she had resisted pressure to provide "extra services" to guests described as VIPs. The resort's owner, Pulkit Arya, son of former BJP minister Vinod Arya, and two employees, Saurabh Bhaskar and Ankit Gupta, were convicted for her murder and sentenced to life imprisonment by a Kotdwar court in May 2023. But that did not put to rest the wider suspicions surrounding the case.

From the outset, scattered imputations engulfed Gautam within the story. He figures nowhere in the chargesheet, has denied all allegations and initiated defamation proceedings against those who made them. What never stopped haunting the case, though, was a basic question: did the probe fully address the VIP angle? ■



HINDUSTAN TIMES



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SITTING IN Congress leaders Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi with Ankita Bhandari's family at India Gate, Oct. 14 and (inset) Sikkim Governor Dushyant Kumar Gautam

Takeaways

- **Ankita Bhandari's parents stage flash protest in Delhi, joined by Rahul, Priyanka**
- **Sought pause on naming Dushyant Gautam as governor, Sikkim; he took oath later**
- **Though immediate suspects were arrested, the shadow of unnamed 'VIP' hung over case**